

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Tribal Culture in India



TRIBAL CULTURE IN INDIA



Tribal Societies in India

Definition of 'Tribe' in India

- According to the *Imperial Gazetteer of India*, a tribe is a collection of families sharing a **common name, dialect**, and **territory**.
- India is a **melting pot** of tribes and races.
- **2nd largest tribal population in the world** after Africa.
- As per the **2011 Census**, the tribal population constitutes **8.9%** of India's total population.

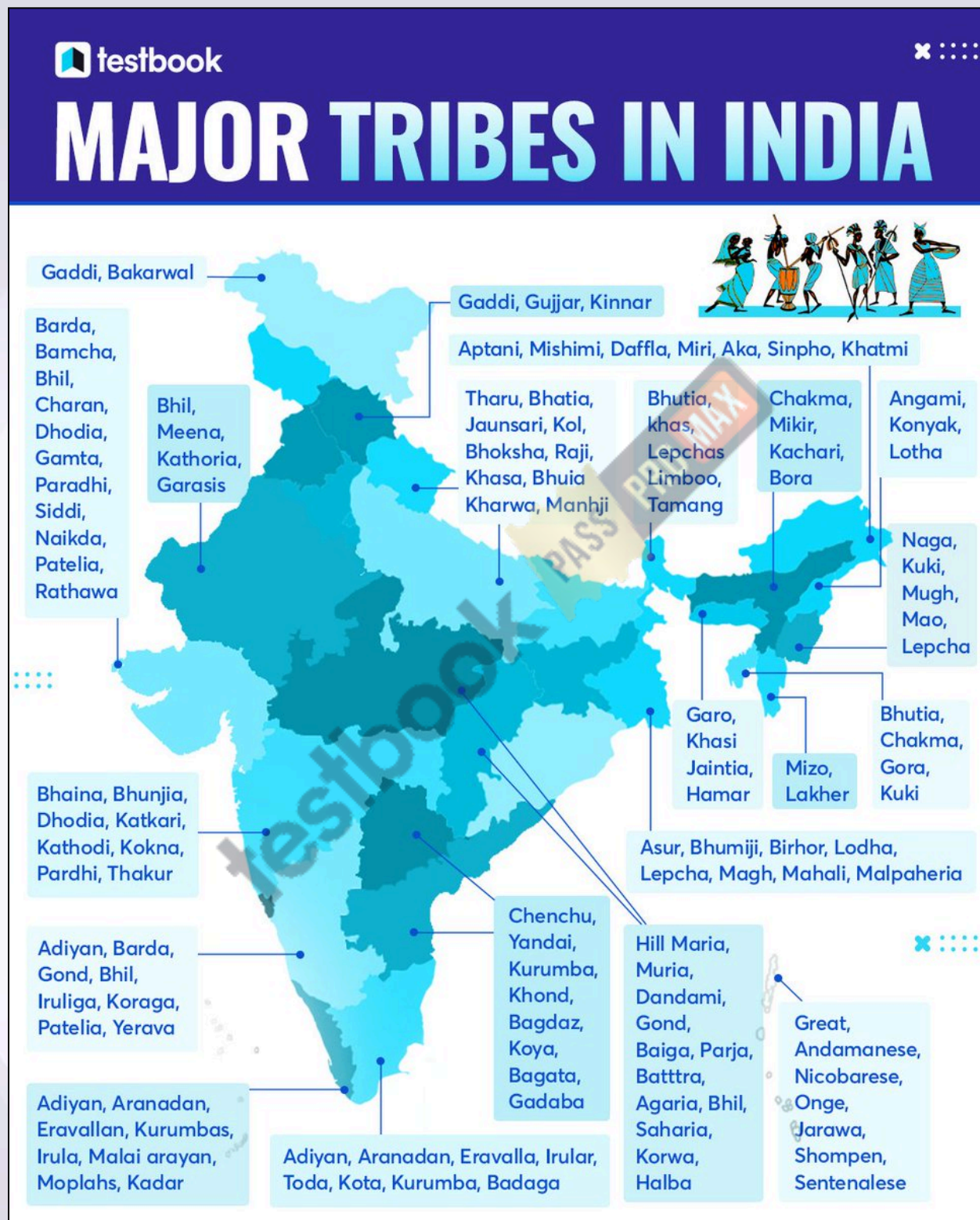
Different Nomenclatures for Tribes in India

- **Adivasis (Indigenous Population)**
 - Original inhabitants of India with distinct cultures, languages, and customs.
 - Deep understanding of the **ecology** and natural resources of their regions.
- **Scheduled Tribes (STs)**
 - Defined in **Article 366 (25)** of the Indian Constitution.

- Identified based on:
 - **Primitive traits**
 - **Geographical isolation**
 - **Distinct culture**
 - **Shyness towards contact with other communities**
 - **Economic backwardness**
- **Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)**
 - Introduced in 1975 based on the recommendation of the **Dhebar Commission** (1973).
 - Total **75 PVTGs** spread across **17 states** and **1 Union Territory (UT)**.
 - Characteristics:
 - **Homogeneous** population
 - **Physical isolation**
 - **Absence of written language**
 - **Simple technology**
 - **Low literacy and economic backwardness**
- **PVTGs by State/UT**

State/UT	PVTGs
Gujarat	Kathodi, Padhar
Odisha	Birhor, Bonda, Dongria Khond
Tripura	Reangs
West Bengal	Birhor, Lodas, Totos
Andaman & Nicobar Islands	Great Andamanese, Jarawas, Onges, Sentinelese, Shom Pens
Karnataka	Jenu Kuruba, Koraga

Major Tribes by State/UT



Categories of Tribal Communities

- **Forest Dwellers**
 - Rely on **forests for livelihoods** (hunting, gathering, non-timber products).
 - Protected under the **Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006**.
- **Denotified Tribes**
 - Once labelled as "**criminal tribes**" under the **Criminal Tribes Act of 1871**.
 - The **act was repealed** post-independence, but these communities continue to face discrimination.
- **Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic Communities**
 - Move with **herds or flocks** in search of resources.
 - Examples: **Banjara, Lambadi, Raika, Rabari, Gaddi**.

How Tribal Communities Differ from Mainstream Society

- **Cultural Practices**
 - Tribes possess unique **languages, customs, and art forms**.
 - Example: The **Warli tribe** in Maharashtra practices **Warli painting** on mud walls during festivals.
- **Economic Practices**
 - Depend on **natural resources** for livelihood (agriculture, handicrafts, hunting).
 - Example: The **Bonda tribe** of Odisha practices shifting cultivation and forest-based livelihoods.
- **Social Organization**
 - Tribal governance relies on **kinship-based systems** and **village councils**.
 - Example: The **Kondh tribe** of Odisha has a village council called 'Gudi' for decision-making.
- **Relationship to Land**
 - A strong **spiritual connection** to the land; belief in **ecological harmony**.
 - Example: **Bhils** of Rajasthan believe their gods reside in forests and rivers.

Contributions of Tribal Communities in India

- **Environmental Conservation**
 - Tribes have sustainable practices for **resource management**.

- Example: **Chenchus** of Andhra Pradesh protects forests and wildlife in the **Nallamala Hills**.
- **Economic Contribution**
 - Engage in **farming, crafts, and forest-based livelihoods**.
 - Example: **Gond tribe** in Madhya Pradesh specializes in metal crafts and shifting cultivation.
- **Traditional Knowledge Systems**
 - Tribes possess **knowledge of medicinal plants and ecological systems**.
 - Example: The **Siddi tribe** practices **honey hunting** and has vast knowledge of local flora.
- **Political Representation**
 - Tribal leaders have **actively contributed to politics** and nation-building.
 - Example: **Droupadi Murmu** (President of India), **Jual Oram** (Former Union Minister of Tribal Affairs).

Important Tribes of India (State-wise and UT-wise)

State / UT	Important Tribes
Andhra Pradesh	Chenchu, Koya, Yerukula, Yanadi, Lambadi
Arunachal Pradesh	Apatani, Nyishi, Monpa, Dafla, Mishmi, Aka
Assam	Bodo, Mishing, Kachari, Karbi, Rabha, Dimasa
Bihar	Santhal, Oraon, Munda, Ho, Bhuiya
Chhattisgarh	Gond, Baiga, Halba, Bison-Horn Maria, Muria
Goa	Dhodia, Siddi, Gowda
Gujarat	Bhil, Dhodia, Rabari, Kathodi, Siddis
Haryana	None (Significant tribal presence not recorded)
Himachal Pradesh	Gaddi, Gujjar, Kinnaura, Bhot

Jharkhand	Santhal, Munda, Oraon, Asur, Birhor, Ho, Kharia
Karnataka	Koraga, Soliga, Jenu Kuruba, Yerava
Kerala	Paniya, Kurumba, Kattunayakan, Irula
Madhya Pradesh	Gond, Bhil, Baiga, Korku, Sahariya
Maharashtra	Warli, Bhil, Katkari, Koli, Thakar
Manipur	Meitei, Naga, Kuki, Zeliangrong
Meghalaya	Khasi, Garo, Jaintia, Hmar
Mizoram	Mizo, Lai, Chakma, Hmar
Nagaland	Angami, Ao, Konyak, Lotha, Sumi
Odisha	Santhal, Bonda, Dongria Kondh, Juang, Gadaba
Punjab	None (Tribal population is minimal)
Rajasthan	Bhil, Meena, Garasia, Saharia
Sikkim	Bhutia, Lepcha, Sherpa, Tamang
Tamil Nadu	Toda, Kota, Irula, Kurumba, Paniya
Telangana	Gond, Lambadi, Kolam, Chenchu
Tripura	Reang, Tripuri, Jamatia, Noatia
Uttar Pradesh	Tharu, Jaunsari, Raji, Kol
Uttarakhand	Bhotia, Tharu, Jaunsari, Raji
West Bengal	Santhal, Toto, Lodha, Birhor, Munda
Andaman and Nicobar Islands	Great Andamanese, Jarawa, Onge, Sentinelese

Chandigarh	None (Tribal presence not recorded)
Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu	Dhodia, Warli, Kokna, Kathodi
Delhi	None (Tribal presence is minimal)
Jammu & Kashmir	Gujjar, Bakarwal, Balti, Brokpa
Ladakh	Brokpa, Changpa
Lakshadweep	None (Tribal status is not applicable)
Puducherry	None (Tribal population is minimal)

Tribal Dances in India (State-wise with Features)

Tribal Dance	State	Features
Warli Dance	Maharashtra	Performed by the Warli tribe, associated with harvest festivals and rituals; dancers move in circles to rhythmic drum beats.
Ghoomar	Rajasthan	Performed by the Bhil tribe, known for its circular movements and colourful attire during celebrations.
Gussadi Dance	Telangana	Performed by the Gonds during the festival of Dussehra, known for elaborate headgear and masks.
Gotipua Dance	Odisha	Performed by young boys dressed as girls to worship Lord Jagannath.
Bagurumba Dance	Assam	Performed by the Bodo tribe, symbolizes nature and wildlife, with dancers imitating butterflies and birds.

Chang Lo Dance	Nagaland	Performed by the Chang tribe during celebrations, featuring war-like movements and energetic steps.
Laho Dance	Meghalaya	Performed by the Khasi tribe, a social dance where men and women dance together, symbolizing unity.
Hojagiri Dance	Tripura	Performed by the Reang tribe, known for balancing acts on earthen pots and bottles.
Bihu Dance	Assam	Performed during the Rongali Bihu festival, it celebrates the Assamese New Year with lively and fast-paced movements.
Dalkhai Dance	Odisha	Performed by the Sambalpuri tribes, associated with seasonal festivals and worship of local deities.
Paika Dance	Odisha	Martial dance performed by tribal warriors, with swords and shields, signifying bravery.
Barda Nati Dance	Himachal Pradesh	Performed by the Gaddi tribe during weddings and festivals.
Chhau Dance	Odisha, Jharkhand, West Bengal	Martial dance that combines folk and tribal traditions, featuring masks and acrobatic movements.
Karma Dance	Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand	Performed by the Gond and Oraon tribes during the Karma festival to celebrate the harvest season.
Saila Dance	Chhattisgarh	Performed by the Baiga tribe, a stick dance performed during post-harvest celebrations.

Tertali Dance	Madhya Pradesh	Performed by the Kamar tribe, women balance earthen pots on their heads and play cymbals tied to their body.
Bamboo Dance (Cheraw)	Mizoram	Performed by the Mizos, dancers step in and out between clapping bamboo sticks.
Kinnauri Nati	Himachal Pradesh	Performed by the Kinnauri tribe during festivals, reflecting joy and prosperity.
Dandiya Raas	Gujarat	Performed by the Rabari tribe with colourful sticks during Navratri celebrations.
Kuduk Dance	Jharkhand	Performed by the Oraon tribe, associated with wedding rituals and community gatherings.
Hikat Dance	Jammu & Kashmir	Traditional dance involving whirling movements, performed by Gujjar and Bakarwal tribes.
Rauf Dance	Jammu & Kashmir	Performed by women during the spring season, symbolizing joy and nature's beauty.
Chholiya Dance	Uttarakhand	A sword dance performed by the Rajput tribes during weddings, symbolised valor.
Puli Kali Dance	Kerala	Tiger dance performed during Onam, representing bravery and power.
Ghumura Dance	Odisha	War dance performed with drum beats is believed to have ancient origins.
Dhimsa Dance	Andhra Pradesh	Performed by the Porja tribe, symbolizing unity and harmony among the tribe.
Kalbelia Dance	Rajasthan	Performed by the Kalbelia tribe, known for its snake-like movements and energetic spins.

Koya Dance	Telangana	Performed by the Koya tribe to celebrate the harvest with drum beats and animal masks.
Thapetta Dance	Andhra Pradesh	Traditional dance performed by the tribal women with drums, to welcome festivals.
Parvathi Dance	Tamil Nadu	Performed by the Toda tribe, reflecting religious rituals and nature worship.
Bharwa Dance	Bihar	Performed by the Santhal tribe, symbolizing rituals for good harvest.
Lambadi Dance	Karnataka, Telangana	Performed by the Lambadi tribe, known for their vibrant costumes and rhythmic steps.

Tribal Festivals in India (State-wise with Features)

Tribal Festival	State	Features
Hornbill Festival	Nagaland	Celebrated by Naga tribes; showcases traditional dance, music, and crafts; called the 'Festival of Festivals.'
Wangala Festival	Meghalaya	Harvest festival of the Garo tribe, marked by traditional drumming and dances.
Dree Festival	Arunachal Pradesh	The agricultural festival of the Apatani tribe, is celebrated with offerings to deities to ensure a good harvest.
Mopin Festival	Arunachal Pradesh	The harvest festival of the Galo tribe, celebrated with rice beer and traditional dances.
Bhagoria Festival	Madhya Pradesh	Known for matchmaking among Bhil tribes, celebrated with fairs and traditional dance.

Chhau Festival	Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal	Combines martial arts and dance with masked performances, celebrated during spring.
Karma Festival	Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh	Celebrates the harvest; worship of the Karma tree is central to this festival.
Sammakka Saralamma Jatara	Telangana	Asia's largest tribal fair honours the tribal goddesses Sammakka and Saralamma.
Kottiyoor Utsavam	Kerala	Tribal temple festival celebrated by the Kurichya and Kuruma tribes.
Sarhul Festival	Jharkhand	Celebrated by the Oraon tribe; marks the flowering of the Sal tree and the arrival of spring.
Bija Pandum	Andhra Pradesh	Celebrated by the Koya tribe with offerings to spirits to protect crops and cattle.
Tusu Parab	West Bengal, Jharkhand	Harvest festival celebrated by the Santhal and Munda tribes with folk songs and dance.
Sital Sasthi	Odisha	Celebrates the divine marriage of Lord Shiva and Goddess Parvati with music and processions.
Maghi Festival	Punjab	Celebrated by the Mazhabi and Ramdasia Sikh tribes to honor sacrifices of warriors.
Perungulam Festival	Tamil Nadu	Celebrated by the Toda tribe, dedicated to their deity and nature worship.
Aoling Festival	Nagaland	Spring festival of the Konyak tribe to mark the arrival of the New Year with dance and food.

Nyokum Festival	Arunachal Pradesh	Celebrated by the Nyishi tribe, involves rituals for prosperity and community welfare.
Pang Lhabso	Sikkim	Celebrated by the Bhutia tribe, honours Mount Kanchenjunga with traditional rituals.
Kharchi Puja	Tripura	Worship of 14 deities by the Tripuri tribe, involves animal sacrifices and music.
Chadak Festival	West Bengal	Celebrated by Santhal and Lodha tribes with devotional practices and rituals.
Galo Seed Sowing Festival	Arunachal Pradesh	An agricultural festival where Galo tribes pray for a good crop yield.
Bathukamma Festival	Telangana	Celebrated by the Lambadi tribe, marked by floral arrangements and songs.
Lokrang Festival	Madhya Pradesh	A cultural festival showcasing the folk traditions of the tribal communities.
Hul Divas	Jharkhand	Commemorates the Santhal Rebellion of 1855 with traditional dances and celebrations.
Nuakhai Festival	Odisha, Chhattisgarh	Celebrated by tribal communities to welcome the new rice crop with feasts and dances.
Chavang Kut	Manipur	Harvest festival celebrated by the Kuki tribe with dances and songs.
Muria Tribal Dance Festival	Chhattisgarh	Traditional dance festival celebrated by the Muria tribe in Bastar.
Paryushan Parva	Gujarat, Rajasthan	Festival of fasting and reflection celebrated by tribal Jains.
Sohrai Festival	Jharkhand, Bihar	Celebrates the harvest and cattle worship; houses are decorated with Sohrai art.

MAJOR TRIBES OF THE WORLD AND THEIR HOMELAND



ESKIMOS

• North America, Green Land, Alaska, North Siberia



KORYAKS

• North Siberia, Eurassian Tunda, North east Asia



LAPPS

• North Finland, Sweden, North Norway



CHUKCHI

• North-East Asia, Russia, North siberia



ALEUTS

• Alaska (US)



BUSHMAN

• Kalahari, Botswana, Namibia



BEDOUIN

• Sahara and Middle East



BINDIBU OR ABORIGINS

• Australia



AINUS

• Japan



RED INDIAN

• North America

